The term '**gana**' means 'people of equal status'. 'Sangha' means 'assembly'. The gana - sanghas covered a small geographical area ruled by an elite group. The gana sanghas practiced egalitarian traditions.

A '**kingdom**' means a territory ruled by a king or queen. In a kingdom (monarchy), a family, which rules for a long period becomes a dynasty. Usually these kingdoms adhered to orthodox Vedic traditions.

Janapadas and Mahajanapadas

Janapadas were the earliest gathering places of men. Later, Janapadas became republics or smaller kingdoms**.** The wide-spread use of iron in Gangetic plain created conditions for the formation of larger territorial units transforming the janapadas into Mahajanapadas.

Sixteen Mahajanapadas ("Great Countries")

Sixteen Mahajanapadas dotted the Indo-Gangetic plain in the sixth century BC (BCE). It was a transition from a semi – nomadic kinship - based society to an agrarian society with networks of trade and exchange. Hence an organized and a strong system of governance required a centralised state apparatus.

DO YOU KNOW?

16 Mahajanapadas

Kuru, Panchala, Anga, Magadha, Vajji, Malla, Kasi, Kosala, Avanti, Chedi, Vatsa, Machcha, Surasena, Assaka, Gandhara and Kamboja.

There were four major Mahajanapadas

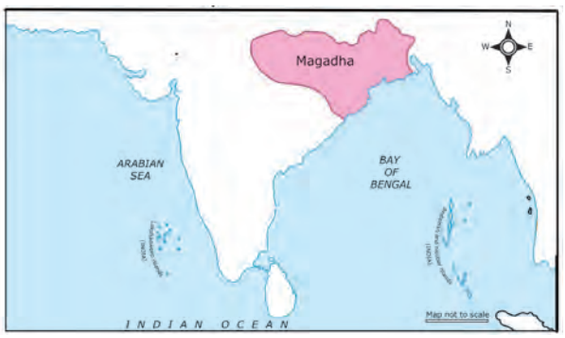
They were:

- Magadha in Bihar
- Avanti in Ujjain
- Kosala in Eastern Uttar Pradesh and
- Vatsa in Kausambi, Allahabad.

Among the four Mahajanapadas, Magadha emerged as an empire.

The Causes for the Rise of Magadha

- Magadha was located on the lower part of the Gangetic plain. The plain was fertile which ensured the rich agricultural yield. This provided regular and substantial income to the state.
- The thick forests supplied timber for construction of buildings and elephants for army.
- Abundance of natural resources especially iron enabled them to equip themselves with weapons made of iron.
- Growing trade and commerce facilitated movement of people as well as settlement of people in centres of arts and crafts.
- The outcome was urbanization and emergence of Magadha as an empire.



Magadha Empire

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